

Boon or bane?

Early success in sport can have a **long-lasting** impact on a young athlete's career.

In today's sporting world, athletes as young as 13 are thrust into the limelight, as seen with a 13-year-old cricketer securing a ₹1.10 crore IPL contract. This phenomenon spans across sports in India — from badminton to football — where young talent is celebrated and monetised early. While these opportunities can be life-changing, they bring enormous psychological consequences.

Early success often robs young athletes of a normal childhood. **Media attention, constant comparisons, and public scrutiny become their new reality.** Young athletes begin to fear losing their spot or fading into irrelevance. These pressures blur the line between personal identity and sporting success. Self-worth becomes dependent on performance, leaving little room for a healthy sense of self.

Moreover, sudden exposure to wealth brings its own challenges. Young athletes often lack financial literacy, and may experience shifts in peer dynamics, with feelings of envy or isolation. Furthermore, the pressure to 'justify' their financial worth places a psychological burden to deliver constant high performance. Their relationship with

the sport becomes transactional leading to heightened anxiety and stress.

But this phenomenon is not without its positives. Young role models are now emerging across sports, inspiring countless children to dream big. Cricketers like Shafali Verma and Riyan Parag have shown what is possible at a young age, breaking barriers and encouraging their peers to set ambitious goals. International stars like Jude Bellingham in football and Coco Gauff in tennis prove that early starts can translate into sustainable success when nurtured appropriately.

That said, this cultural shift has drawbacks. Today, playing in the IPL or winning a world championship at the age of 13 or 14 may be achievable for some, but they can be counterproductive for others. Not every child will become a professional athlete. Sports should also be valued for fitness, fun, and overall development rather than just competition. **By tying sports participation solely to success, we risk alienating children who may not excel competitively but would still benefit from playing.** Ensuring that young athletes enjoy regular childhood activities is critical. Parents

and coaches can foster this balance by setting aside dedicated time for hobbies, unstructured play, or social activities outside of sports.

In the whirlwind of fame and financial success, mental health is often sidelined. Many young athletes lack access to emotional regulation tools, coping strategies, or life skills to manage their unique challenges. The absence of sports psychologists or a support system leaves them vulnerable to stress, burnout, and long-term mental health struggles.

Parents play a crucial role in shaping how young athletes navigate fame and expectations. Instead of projecting unfulfilled dreams, parents must offer unconditional emotional support. Encouraging balance between sports, education, and social life ensures their child's holistic development.

Young athletes deserve more than just success — they deserve balance, growth, and well-being. It requires a multi-stakeholder approach involving parents, coaches, team management, and sports psychologists. By prioritising mental health, financial education, and a process-driven mindset, we can ensure that young talent thrives sustainably. The ultimate goal is to help young athletes build a foundation for long-term success while protecting their mental and emotional well-being. Only then can they enjoy the sport they love while achieving their true potential.

The author is a sports and exercise psychologist who graduated from Loughborough University.

FOR PARENTS

Dos:

Encourage balance between sports, education, and social activities.
Provide unconditional emotional support, irrespective of results.
Reinforce the idea that failure is part of growth.

Don'ts:

Project unfulfilled dreams or ambitions onto the child.
Tie the child's worth solely to performance or results.
Neglect signs of burnout or emotional distress.

FOR YOUNG ATHLETES

Dos:

Focus on skill development and enjoying the sport.
Build a 'failure resume' to learn from past experiences.
Seek mentorship and guidance from experienced athletes.

Don'ts:

Let success create a bubble of infallibility.
Compare constantly with peers or succumb to envy.
Ignore opportunities for personal growth beyond sports.